



A COMMUNITY OF CHOICE

PLANNING AND DEVELOPMENT SERVICES

URBAN PLANNING OFFICE

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MEMO

TO: Casey Palma

FROM: Brandon Cammarata, Planning & Development Director

SUBJECT: Scenic Subdivision, Staff response to Addendum 1

DATE: February 1, 2013

On January 7, 2013, the Cheyenne Planning Commission recommended denial of the Preliminary Plat and Zone Change for Scenic Subdivision. The Commission cited that the transportation network plan submitted by the applicant is not consistent with the adopted transportation network plan, which is a requirement under Section 4.3.2. The Commission also described a concern with the lack of pedestrian and street connections to the immediately adjacent commercial activities. The Commission expressed concern about whether sufficient open space would be provided. The Cheyenne Planning Commission also expressed concern over the planning of the drainage features in the area beyond the plat boundaries without coordinating streets and open space beyond the plat.

The applicant has requested the preliminary plat and zone change be brought before the governing body.

The application does attempt to rectify the transportation network with a revised transportation network plan that is consistent with the PlanCheyenne Master Transportation Plan. The following items were discussed with the applicant and need to be made consistent with the proposed network plan.

1. Identify the street being platted as Melton Street. Melton Street is the local street at this alignment west of Powderhouse. Naming the street Melton clarifies the intent reflected in the network plan the applicant submitted, as opposed to the Carlson Street name which is not consistent with the network plan submitted.
2. Classify the street as a local street. Similar reasoning as above, Melton Street is a local street whereas Carlson Street is a collector street. This is an important distinction because local streets serve a different purpose than collector streets and are constructed differently as well (UDC Table 4-5).

3. Flatten the alignment of Melton Street on the Plat. The revised network plan no longer reflects a connection to Carlson Street from this plat, thus it is not appropriate for Melton Street to be angled to the north and west.

The above mentioned adjustment has minimal impact to the proposed apartment complex and a predictable impact on the future transportation system.

By working with a typical and previously studied transportation system, there are clear expectations relating to future performance and required investments. A typical transportation system means there are best practices where particular spacing of streets and frequency of streets tends to work well, providing multiple routes for citizens and the effective provision of emergency and other services, as well as proper spacing for signalization and intersection functions. This does not mean that viable alternatives do not exist, but they should be examined comprehensively to better understand any functional ramifications or additional investments. This is why the transportation system has been a major point of concern with the Scenic project and the Bluffs 9th Filing. Both projects suggest major changes in the transportation system. The initial proposals push large amounts of traffic onto Converse Avenue close to the Dell Range intersection. This limits options for functional signalization, and is likely to complicate matters near the Converse/Dell Range intersection. The initial proposal also provides little in the way of alternate routes and connections to destinations. All of these factors increase the risk of a poorly functioning transportation system and a potentially more costly system for the taxpayers.

Attached is additional information provided by the City Engineer's Office and the Metropolitan Planning Organization (MPO). This memo and attachments should be considered in conjunction with the previously produced staff report.

Attached: Additional comments from City Engineer and MPO

2/1/13
City Engineer

Scenic Apartments City Council Appeal

With the "appeal" the developer encourages the City Council to look objectively at the cost-benefit analysis of a project such as Scenic Development. What is not encouraged however is that City Council look at the adverse impacts associated with development and the costs associated with mitigation of those adverse impacts? The developer provided Transportation Impact Study (TIS) identifies that the Intersection at Converse Avenue and Dell Range Boulevard has the highest number of crashes and the highest crash rate during the last ten years. The intersection currently operates at a Level of Service (LOS) "F". A LOS "F" indicates poor, congested operating conditions. This project alone will produce 2,234 average daily trips with 90 percent (2011 trips) of that traffic heading south on Converse Avenue to Dell Range. The street section of Converse Avenue from the proposed project connection with Converse Avenue to just north of the intersection of Converse Avenue and Dell Range Boulevard is not fully constructed. The TIS recommends construction of traffic signals at the intersections of the project collector street with Converse Avenue and the intersection of Point Bluff with Converse Avenue. The cost to the City to make improvements to the intersection of Converse Avenue and Dell Range Boulevard to - improve the level of service, complete the roadway section from Dell Range Boulevard to the project collector street connection to Converse Avenue and provide traffic signals at the TIS recommended locations, could exceed two million dollars, to the detriment of the City and to the entire community. Deferring discussions on the road network plan as development occurs, as suggested in Mr. Cole's letter dated January 4, 2013, will only build on the success or failure of the existing road network system. Which already has a history of safety and/or accident problems and to which the scale of the overall proposed development is likely to lead to an increase in delay and to less than acceptable levels of service on adjacent public streets and intersections. To imply that this project just increases the risk of a poorly functioning transportation system is an understatement. There are improvements that are necessary now and that will be exasperated with development of this project and future projects in the area.

We hereby incorporate all previous comments made by Traffic Engineering on the previous submittals by reference and supplement those comments with the following:

1. Developments with over fifty (50) dwelling units should have at least 3 connections or routes to an existing arterial or collector street and one additional connection or route for every increment of fifty (50) dwelling units (ref. article 4, Section 4.3.3.f., UDC). Without adequate access and connectivity to the project site, the response time for fire and police will be adversely impacted. A two lane access road should be constructed as part of this project connecting the proposed apartment complex with Rue Terre.
2. For development to occur, the developer will need to build or fund construction of any roadways or infrastructure that is necessary to provide access, increase capacity and/or mitigate adverse impacts of development. Costs and responsibilities associated with transportation often lie entirely on developers in designing and building any infrastructure necessitated by the proposed development. Improvements to the intersection of Converse Avenue and Dell Range Boulevard should be recommended and implemented as part of this project.

3. The continued approval of Development Actions as piecemeal stand alone projects and preceding an approved Master Transportation Planning Study will only build on the success or failure of the existing roadway system. We need to take steps to prevent past mistakes from recurring.



MEMO

TO: Mayor Rick Kaysen and Cheyenne City Council
FROM: Tom Mason, MPO Director
SUBJECT: Scenic and Bluffs 9th and Transportation History
DATE: February 1, 2013

Mayor and Council: I will not be able to attend the February 5 Public Service Committee so I wanted to give my support to the recommendations of the Development Office with this history and explanation behind the support.

North Dell Range Traffic Patterns and Transportation Plan

Buffalo Ridge was developed in the 1950's and at that time the land use, transportation network, and block pattern for the neighborhood were established. This pattern displayed in Figure 1, shows that the street system collected all traffic and turned it southward towards Dell Range which, at the time, was a small two-lane road and traffic volumes were very light. Mid-twentieth century Cheyenne was too early for the recognition of the importance of regional transportation planning, as this later adopted practice, helped guide subdivision's roadway networks to take into account the hierarchy and functions of mobility and access such as connections to future growth beyond their own boundaries.

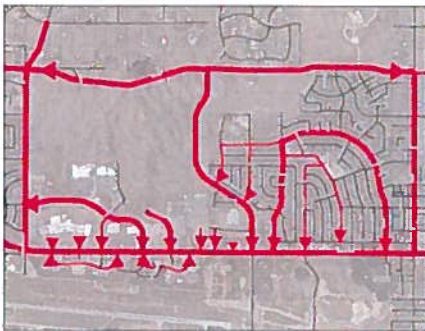


Figure 1

Eventually, in the 80's Crest Ridge was platted and began development but due to elevation changes, only two local streets made connections to Dell Range through the existing Buffalo Ridge neighborhood.

Then in the late 70's the approval of Frontier Mall was granted by City Council. This was the beginning of the soon to be primary commercial area for the City of Cheyenne which helped lead to the decline of the downtown. The same transportation system pattern which was implemented in Section 21- Buffalo Ridge is now being repeated in Section 20. Prairie Avenue turned south to Dell Range as did Rue Terre.

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In 1992 the K-Mart Plat, which included the Rue Terre right-of-way, was approved and the future major traffic generators (Sam's, Walmart, and Post Office) were not even envisioned. The MPO and the city staff at that time put forth the argument to convince the Planning Commission and City Governing Body that if the K-Mart Plat went through as proposed, the option of extending Prairie eastward toward Converse Avenue would not happen. It was recognized then that a recommended parallel street to Dell Range, a "backside street" to the Mall and other future Dell Range frontages would not be able to be built. The obvious problem created which still persists today, was that a significant volume of traffic to and from these major stores cut through the adjoining parking lots (or the back side of K-Mart) in lieu of travel to and from Dell Range to go from store to store. This section of Dell Range between Rue Terre and Converse carries the highest volumes of traffic in the State of Wyoming (approaching 30,000 a day) for a commercial stretch and also has some of the highest traffic crashes in the community. (Dell Range and Converse is ranked 1st with 325 crashes in the last 10 years and Rue Terre and Dell Range is ranked 7th with 153.

Now in 2013, the Cheyenne MPO, City Engineering and Planning staffs are striving to eliminate the continuation of poor traffic patterns such as those started in the 50's and which will further compound the traffic problems on Dell Range. Diverting all traffic south to Dell Range has not been the only failure of the network.

The past placement of traffic signals at non-optimal spacing, which was dictated by development, is also an issue because the traffic signals cannot be coordinated efficiently so that traffic moves smoothly each direction. This leads to a significant number of rear-end crashes. Another issue is that piece-meal development in Section 20 and 21 has not resulted in good connectivity between each development. In other words, motorists and non-motorized travelers must go around developments to move between them instead of logical and more direct connections being made. People are forced to drive, rather than walk, to get between different stores and/or their homes. An example of this is the proposed Scenic Development off Converse Avenue north of Dell Range. There are no streets or pedestrian connection from these 336 apartments to the stores located south or west of them. People will be forced to drive from Scenic to Converse and Dell Range or Masonway to get to Sam's, Walmart, etc.

Good, sound transportation planning practices of today follow a grid system where the traffic is more evenly distributed throughout the street system. Turning all traffic south to Dell Range and not providing good connectivity with equally spaced north-south and east-west streets will cause even more



unnecessary traffic congestion and higher crash rates on Dell Range. Figure 2 demonstrates this principal while taking into account the existing infrastructure.

PlanCheyenne was developed by the citizens of Cheyenne and the transportation plan in Section 20 (Figure 2) shows an east-west and north-south arterial which lays the groundwork and framework for a grid system in the hopes to correct and improve the network in this area by providing parallel relief and mobility.

Figure 2

Given the preliminary plats of the proposed Bluffs 9th Filing and Scenic Development, concern is raised that failures of previous practices of the past are continuing and modern transportation planning and engineering practices are not being implemented. It is very important that other future major streets built within Section 20 do not encourage the intentional distribution of traffic from this area, and from beyond this area, to the already overly congested Dell Range and Converse intersection. What is being proposed by the conceptual network map associated with the Scenic Traffic Study seems to follow this pattern; Carlson in a diagonal in the northwest to southeast direction. The PlanCheyenne east/west collector which would be the westward extension of Plainview from Buffalo Ridge to a four-way intersection at Converse (on the north edge of Bluffs 9th) and continuing westward to Powderhouse is a very important corridor even though existing infrastructure might make it more challenging. This would provide a logical and best case scenario connection between the Indian Hills and Buffalo Ridge/Crest Ridge neighborhoods.

Mr. Cole has stated many times that he encouraged the WYDOT and City to buy more right-of-way from his family so that the Dell Range corridor could have been made wider, i.e. – seven lanes. Traffic forecasts done thirty years ago may have underestimated the growth of Cheyenne around this area, however the MPO Office believes that the current five lanes would be sufficient if proactive transportation planning, engineering and development guidelines were implemented. This includes detaching the sidewalk wherever possible to increase pedestrian safety.

The MPO is beginning a study of the Dell Range and Prairie corridors. It is our hope that some new and different solutions can be presented and implemented to make the corridor more efficient and safer. In the meantime the MPO Office encourages the City Governing Body to consider this history of the area and support the staff recommendations concerning the plat for the Bluffs 9th Filing and Scenic development. The most important of these are: 1) right of way must be platted on the north side of the Bluffs 9th for the future Plainview extension to a four-way intersection with Converse, 2) the western end of the street on the north side of Scenic must turn west and flatten out so that it does not point northwest toward Carlson, this street must be called Melton and point toward the Melton and Powderhouse intersection, 3) there must be street and pedestrian connections southward from the west side of Scenic to make future or concurrent connections toward Rue Terre. Not only is this needed for alternative trips to and from Scenic other than by way of Converse, but for Fire/Emergency response options and non-motorized connections.